SPACE TOURISM

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

The red dust of Suncatcher did not merely settle; it had ambitions.

It was a fine, iron-heavy powder with the consistency of pulverized emery paper and the persistence of a junior tax collector. It bypassed atmospheric airlock gaskets, insinuated itself into the lubricated ball bearings of heavy mining crawlers, and had long since established permanent colonies inside the socks of every human being who had ever set foot on the moon. If you lived in Dustwall long enough, you learned that your teeth never quite touched without a faint, dry crunch, and that attempting to maintain a clean white shirt was legally classified as an act of municipal insanity.

Which was why Tessa, standing on the observation walkway of the city's Great Wall with an adjustable hydraulic spanner tucked into her tool belt, was staring at her client with the slow, horrified fascination of an engineer watching someone pour fine sugar into a reactor intake.

"It is magnificent," Valis said.

Valis was an Ancestral from Irul'lia, which meant he was tall, possessed the pale, alabaster grace of an uncarved marble statue, and moved with the serene, effortless balance of a species that had spent several hundred thousand years never once having to sprint to catch a bus. He was dressed in shimmering, high-collared silks woven from radiotrophic taiga ferns—a garment that on Irul would have commanded the respectful silence of a cathedral. Over this, however, Valis had draped an aggressively loud, short-sleeved cotton vest printed with violent neon-yellow citrus fruits and electric-blue silhouettes of dancing Newcomer musicians. He had bought it three days ago at a street stall on Avon 2, and he wore it with the unshakeable dignity of an emperor wearing a coronation mantle. Hanging around his slender neck was a digital holocam slate—a sleek, brushed-alloy device with a high-resolution optical sensor and a glowing glass interface.

"It's a slag heap, Valis," Tessa said wearily, wiping a smudge of grease from her protective goggles. Tessa was a third-generation crawler mechanic from Dustwall, which meant she viewed scenery primarily in terms of its abrasive index and tensile strength. Since taking a Corsair charter and flying corvettes for the Flotilla, she had seen planetary rings, binary eclipses, and the cold, terrifying majesty of deep-void dreadnoughts. None of them, in her professional opinion, justified wearing a lemon-patterned vest in an industrial mining settlement. "It's four million tons of low-grade basalt tailings dumped out by the primary smelter. Even with the Great Wall out here holding back the worst of the desert sandstorms, enough grit drifts over the parapet to turn your fancy silk trousers into thirty-grit sandpaper."

Valis tapped the slate's glass face, the capture saving into memory with a soft pulse of light while a miniature preview floated above the screen. "A monument to honest exertion," Valis corrected pleasantly, admiring the sharp capture on his display. "In the Upper Spires of Irul'lia, our refuse is dissolved at the molecular level by harmonic resonance scrubbers. It is exceedingly tidy, of course, but it completely lacks drama. One never gets the impression that anyone had to sweat to achieve it. Here, the struggle between mortal will and stubborn geology is written upon the very horizon. Look at that glorious mechanical behemoth!"

He pointed a slender, immaculate finger across the open mining basin beyond the wall. Half a mile away, shuddering through the heat shimmer of midday, rose *The Gilded Bore*. It was a bucket-wheel excavator the size of a municipal hospital, its six-story steel wheel chewing rhythmically into the red sandstone cliff with a relentless, bone-shaking rhythmic crunch that vibrated straight through the soles of Tessa's magnetic work boots. Great plumes of reddish-black silica billowed from its exhaust stacks, catching the harsh glare of the sun before settling back down toward the desert plains.

"That," Tessa muttered, "is fourteen thousand tons of un-greased scrap metal that breaks an axle every Tuesday shift. If my father hadn't retired to Crossroads to grow plums, he'd be down in that gear-box right now with a cutting torch, swearing in four different colonial dialects."

"Fascinating," Valis breathed, his golden eyes wide with sincere delight. "Your father must be an artist of extraordinary temperament. Shall we descend into the concourse? My itinerary indicates that we are scheduled to inspect the municipal market before the celestial occlusion."

Tessa sighed, tapped the environmental gauge on her forearm console, and unlatched the heavy transit hatch leading down from the battlements. "Mind the steps. And for the love of the stars, Valis, if anyone offers to sell you an 'authentic Precursor cooling rod' out of a wheelbarrow, keep your hands in your pockets. It's just a spray-painted radiator core from an old tractor."

The lower commercial concourse of Dustwall was less of an open street and more of a heavily fortified industrial thoroughfare sheltered behind the city's colossal outer barrier. Though Suncatcher possessed a breathable atmosphere like every terraformed moon across the Sphere, its dry, low-humidity air carried an iron bite, and its surface took the brunt of extreme thermal swings. When the sun hung high, the iron plains outside baked into shimmering heat traps, driving the populace into the shaded lower concourses and deep-chilled foundry tunnels. Overhead, massive yellow pipes hissed with pressurized ammonia coolant, sweating condensation into rusted drip-pans that local urchins guarded like gold mines.

The air smelled intensely of scorched machine oil, sulfurous slag, boiled cabbage, and the bitter, roasted chicory beverage that the local Craggen miners drank by the gallon. Painted in peeling white stencils above every pressure door was the Consortium's solemn civic creed: *Respect the Vent, Guard the Seal, Mind the Gauge.*

Valis strolled through the clamor like an immortal prince inspecting a particularly lively country fair. To the miners, dockhands, and heavy equipment haulers crowding the concourse, he was a spectacle of alarming proportions. Craggen stone-carvers—small, dense folk barely four feet tall, like lean, gnomish dark iron dwarves with skin of chisel-marked basalt and eyes like glowing cut garnets—paused with their mugs of chicory halfway to their stony lips, squinting up in disbelief at Valis's radiant silk robe and loud tourist vest. Slender Naga pipe-fitters coiled along overhead steam conduits flicked their forked tongues, their neck crests flushing a bewildered indigo.

"Greetings!" Valis announced cheerfully to a table of four heavily muscled human drillers whose hazard suits were caked in red grit. "May your thermal conduits remain unimpeded and your extraction quotas bring spiritual harmony to your lineage!"

The drillers stared at him in dead silence. One of them slowly looked down at his own grease-blackened wrench, then back up at Valis's immaculate face, and finally over at Tessa.

"Relative of yours, Tess?" the driller asked in a voice like two gravel trucks colliding.

"Diplomatic contract, Brant," Tessa said flatly, keeping one hand resting casually on the butt of her sidearm. "He's an Ancestral scholar. He looks, he takes pictures, he doesn't touch anything, and the Flotilla pays my docking fees for three months. Go back to your soup."

Brant grunted, shook his head, and went back to sawing through a piece of synthetic salt-beef that looked capable of deflecting a railgun slug.

"They possess remarkable physical density," Valis observed quietly as they moved past a row of sputtering kerosene cook-stoves. "And a very direct economy. I noticed Brant did not offer to exchange digital credits. He had a brass token stamped with an anvil."

"Caldera Foundry scrip," Tessa said, steering him deftly around an open drainage sump where greasy wastewater gurgled beneath iron grating. "You work a twelve-hour shift at the smelting furnaces, the company credits your slate. But out here in the rim-blocks, the comm-relays cut out whenever a solar flare clips the magnetosphere. So the company mints brass chits. You buy your water with foundry brass, you rent your bunk with foundry brass, and when you die, the foundry charges your next-of-kin three chits to recycle your hazard suit. It's not spiritual harmony, Valis. It's a closed-loop accounting trap."

Valis paused, tapping a quick note onto his slate. "A fascinating mechanism of societal continuity. On Irul'lia, we have no chits. When one requires a garment, or a meal of radiotrophic moss-loaf, one simply presents oneself at the Distribution Spires. The Triumvirate maintains the quotas, the automated dynamos produce the goods, and everyone receives precisely what was allotted to their generational cohort three thousand years ago."

Tessa stopped dead on the metal decking and turned to look at him. "You mean nobody argues about the bill?"

"Never," Valis said, genuinely puzzled by the suggestion. "Why would one argue with a dynamo? The dynamo is a holy instrument left to us by the Precursors. To suggest it has under-delivered would be an impious critique of paradise."

Tessa rubbed the bridge of her nose, right where her goggles had left a deep red groove in her skin. "I swear, Valis, half the fun of buying a bowl of noodles in Dustwall is spending ten minutes telling the cook his broth tastes like bilge water until he knocks two copper bits off the price."

"A ritual contest of determination," Valis noted solemnly, nodding as if he had just uncovered a profound cosmic truth. "I shall record that in my dissertation."

At the eastern edge of the concourse, where the steel overhangs opened out into a wide, dusty recreation lot sheltered by the inner curve of the Great Wall, a tremendous uproar echoed across the yard. It was not the sound of an industrial accident, nor the panicked shouting that accompanied a breached pressure line. It was the distinct, full-throated, profoundly joyous roar of forty off-shift workers watching a sporting contest. Valis's eyes lit up. Before Tessa could grab his festival vest, he had already glided through the perimeter gate and into the yard.

The lot was a flat, unpaved stretch of red sandlot, bounded by an old chain-link fence and a row of parked maintenance crawlers. Across the dirt, someone had laid out a textbook baseball diamond: four canvas bags anchored with steel pegs, sixty feet apart, with lines of white gypsum chalk marking out the baselines.

In the batter's box stood a wiry, three-meter Naga mechanic wearing a backwards cap, his long muscular tail coiled for balance as he rested a smoothed ash-wood bat across his scaly shoulder. Sixty feet away on the pitcher's mound, Marik, a lean, compact Craggen drill-operator in a grease-stained undershirt—scarcely coming up to an ordinary man's chest, but built like a solid block of dark cast iron—was palming a scuffed, red-stitched baseball with his chisel-carved stone fingers. Behind the plate, an elderly human umpire in dusty denim squatted behind a wire catcher's mask, his knuckles resting on his knees.

"Come on, Ssaros!" a woman on the team bench shouted, rattling the chain-link fence. "Put the wood on it! Two outs, bottom of the seventh, bring the runners home!"

The Craggen pitcher nodded, shook off a sign, and dropped into a low, coiled windup. His dense basalt arm whipped forward like a leaf-spring, hurling the ball with a sharp, spinning hiss. Fastball, belt-high, right over the heart of the plate. The Naga batter didn't hesitate. His tail uncoiled like a steel spring, driving his torso through a clean, picture-perfect swing.

The solid, unmistakable crack of hardwood meeting leather rang out across the entire yard. The ball launched into the thin desert air in a soaring, majestic arc, climbing higher and higher into the sunlight, sailing clean over the outfielders' reaching gloves, over the chain-link fence, and clearing the corrugated roof of a storage shed two hundred feet away.

"IT'S GONE!" the crowd shrieked in unison. "HOME RUN!" the umpire bellowed, pumping his fist into the air with theatrical gusto.

The entire bench cleared. Off-shift miners, mechanics, and weld-inspectors swarmed out into the dust, cheering, laughing, and banging metal lunchboxes against the fence posts. The two runners on base trotted home, followed by Ssaros, who rounded third base with a wide, triumphant grin, casually tossing his bat aside before slapping hands with half the spectators.

Valis stood at the edge of the fence, his digital slate chiming softly as he captured a burst of high-speed photos. His face was flushed with pure, incandescent wonder. "Old Earth baseball," Valis whispered reverently. "The sacred liturgy of the diamond."

Tessa leaned against a fence post, crossing her arms with an amused grin. "You know about this?"

"Of course!" Valis said, his eyes shining as he scrolled through the photos of the laughing players. "On Avon 2, during the Festival of the Solstice, the Newcomer communities clear temporary diamonds on the moss plains. I spent two whole cycles studying the archives. It is an astonishing sociological phenomenon, Tessa. Your ancestors crossed the lightless void in great cryogenic arks, carrying the sum total of human wisdom—quantum mechanics, cellular synthesis, stellar navigation—and nestled right alongside those monumental truths, they brought the rules for hitting a stitched leather ball with a piece of wood."

"My grandfather used to play third base for the Caldera Foundry team," Tessa said, a faint, nostalgic smirk tugging at the corner of her mouth. "He broke his collarbone sliding into home plate during the 502 AA championship against the Water Harvesters. He kept the bent cleat on his mantelpiece until the day he died. Said it was the proudest day of his life."

"Why?" Valis asked, genuinely enthralled. "What did he win? A concession of territory? A reduction in labor tariffs?"

"A battered tin cup that leaked from the bottom," Tessa replied. "And the right to call the Water Harvester foreman a blind idiot in the commissary for twelve months without getting punched."

Valis watched as the three-meter Naga batter coiled triumphantly down in the dust, grinning from ear to ear as a pack of compact Craggen teammates swarmed around him to pound his scaly ribs and dump a cup of cold water over his head.

"It is sublime," Valis murmured. "In our archives, we have records of another human pastime—the game of *Chess*. Two kings, two queens, four bishops, four knights, four castles, and sixteen pawns, all locked upon a sixty-four-square grid of black and white stone. Two elderly scholars will sit across a table for four hours in absolute, agonizing silence, contemplating whether a carved wooden horse should jump in the shape of an 'L'. And when the horse finally jumps, the other scholar groans as if he has suffered a mortal wound to his soul."

"Silas plays chess," Tessa said. "Our crew's tech specialist. Spends half his downtime on the ship staring at a little magnetic board, rubbing his chin. Drives Jax crazy. Jax just wants to hit things with his boarding axe."

"Do you not see the genius of it?" Valis turned to her, his long fingers gesturing toward the celebrating ballplayers. "Your people have engineered a civilization where survival is precarious, unpredictable, and often deeply unfair. The rock breaks when it should hold; the air scrubber fails when you need to breathe; the Flotilla passes laws you did not vote for. And so, to keep from screaming into the dark, you invent tiny, artificial universes where the rules are absolute, entirely arbitrary, and completely meaningless. You draw a line in the red dust, you declare that hitting a ball over a shed is a moment of pure triumph, and for two hours, you can celebrate with all your heart about something that has no consequence whatsoever. It is a vaccine against despair."

Tessa looked at the laughing miners, watching the losing team hand over a handful of brass foundry chits with good-natured grumbling. "I never thought about it like that," she admitted slowly. "I just thought miners liked having an excuse to hit things and drink beer after a ten-hour shift."

"That too," Valis smiled gently. "Pragmatism and poetry are frequently roommates in mortal history."

They left the ballgame behind and climbed a broad iron staircase to the upper parapet of the Dust Wall. Here, high above the rooftops, the industrial rumble of Dustwall faded into a steady, distant thrum. The view opened out into the vast, terrible grandeur of the Suncatcher badlands: wind-carved sandstone plateaus and crimson dunes stretching toward a jagged horizon, shimmering beneath a blistering sun that hung in the deep-blue sky like an unshielded fusion torch.

They sat down on an iron bench welded directly to the parapet stanchions. Tessa pulled a battered thermos from her pack, unscrewed the cap, and poured two cups of steaming, dark-brown chicory. She handed one to Valis. He took it with two hands, inhaling the bitter, roasted steam. He took a tiny, polite sip, paused, and blinked.

"It tastes," Valis said carefully, "as though someone burned a pine cone, ground it into dust, and boiled it in battery acid."

"That's the high-grade stuff," Tessa grinned. "The cheap stuff strips the enamel off your molars. Drink up. It keeps the dust from sticking to your throat."

Valis took another sip, his face settling into an expression of stoic academic endurance. "Tell me, Tessa. As a Corsair who travels between the spheres... how do your people endure the leaders of these worlds? From Irul'lia, Newcomer civilization appears less like a government and more like a collection of very stubborn arguments drifting in parallel orbits."

Tessa chuckled into her cup. "That's because it *is* an argument, Valis. That's the whole point."

She leaned back against the iron railing, looking out toward the horizon where the sun was beginning to touch the distant purple rim of Nimbus.

"Take Crossroads," Tessa began. "Down on Landfall. You've got the High Council. Speaker Jesse Haddon sits at a cedar table he built himself thirty years ago, surrounded by five lineage delegates who would rather eat broken glass than agree on a property tax. When they want to dig a drainage ditch behind the orchard, they don't just dig it. They hold three public readings. They commission an environmental impact report to make sure the local river beetles won't get offended. They spend four hours debating whether the rocket shuttles taking off from the south field are blowing too much soot onto the town councilwoman's clean bedsheets."

Valis smiled faintly. "And does anyone listen?"

"Oh, everyone listens," Tessa said. "Especially Goldheart. The old dragon sits on the council terrace with his chin on the marble railing, eating roasted apples and chiming in whenever he feels like it. If the councilors start yelling at each other, Goldheart lets out a little rumble that rattles the tea cups and reminds them that haste is the enemy of good manners. It takes six months to pave a street, but nobody gets shot, nobody starves, and the bedsheets stay reasonably white."

"A deliberative democracy tempered by draconic avuncularity," Valis noted. "Charming. And Nimbus?"

Tessa's expression shifted. "Cloudspire is a different beast entirely. It's a pure, hyper-capitalist technocracy wrapped in neon and rain, all perched across high-altitude plateaus. The Arcology Directorate runs the show—corporate consortiums, precision avionics cartels, and high-frequency data exchanges where money moves at the speed of light."

"Altitude is status, corporate shares are law, and half the city's engineers spend eighteen hours a day trying to patent a faster circuit."

"And does anyone govern their ambitions?" Valis asked.

"Stormdrinker," Tessa said, nodding toward the sky. "The Scholar Dragon. He perches high above the Cloudspire towers, watching everything with eyes like lightning storms. The corporations might own the patents and the trading floors, but Stormdrinker holds the ultimate veto. If the boardrooms get too reckless or start digging into forbidden research that threatens the sky, the dragon steps in with the weight of an empire. It's a cutthroat capitalist jungle, but it stays standing because a five-hundred-year-old cosmic scholar has a very heavy thumb on the scale."

"A technocratic oligarchy monitored by an ancient draconic sovereign," Valis whispered, his golden eyes narrowing in quiet fascination. "A precarious equilibrium of ledger books and apex power."

"And then you have Pelagia," Tessa continued, waving her cup toward the sky where the water-world drifted in co-orbital harmony. "Ruled by Land Barons who had the capital to create their artificial islands as their own little kingdoms. Whatever natural land there is though is kind of like Nimbus just without any dragons, and with more water."

"And the Orks?" Valis asked.

"The Orks don't have councils," Tessa snorted. "They have an emperor. And slavery. And violence. Lots of it. I don't know how he does it but Vrakketh manages to steer all of that frenzy in the direction he points his finger at and they listen to him. Must be one hell of an ork," she said, then paused—"Not that I don't hate his guts like everybody on this side of the DMZ."

"And the void between them?" Valis asked, gesturing toward the stars. "The Flotilla that brought me here?"

"The Flotilla has the Admiralty Board," Tessa said. "Twelve line admirals sitting in high-orbit command dreadnoughts, looking at radar boards and casualty charts."

"And here?" Valis looked down at the iron rooftops and smoking flues of the concourse below. "Who governs this moon?"

Tessa looked out over the parapet, her eyes softening as she watched the distant dust plumes on the plain. "Nobody."

Valis blinked in surprise. "Nobody?"

"Suncatcher isn't a state, Valis. It's just a scatter of mining settlements and drilling camps trying to get by in the red dust. The Badlands out there are a lawless, sun-baked meat grinder where rogue crawlers fight over water wells and scrap. But in Dustwall... there are no politics. No corporate boardrooms, no lineage delegates, no taxes. The whole reason we're organized is that folks asked the best man they knew for the job to be Aldorman—old Aldorman Grady. He's a retired bore-mechanic, rough around the edges, with hands like iron anvils and a voice like a rockslide. But he's fair, honest, and good and proper. When folks have a dispute over a smelting quota or a water valve, they take it to Grady's porch, he listens, he spits in the dust, and he gives an answer. And people listen because he earned it."

"And the law?" Valis asked, genuinely enthralled. "Who enforces the Aldorman's judgments?"

"The Dustwall Rovers," Tessa said, nodding toward the lower gate where two riders in long canvas dusters were checking the latch on a tracked buggy, heavy steel bolas and carbines slung from their saddles. "They're not funded by any planetary budget. Most of them are rough-and-tumble locals, vagabonds, and grease-monkeys with a sharper moral compass than most. The community volunteers food, foundry scrip, and spare parts to keep them supplied because everybody knows they're just and trustworthy."

"If a crawler breaks down in a silica storm, or a bandit pack creeps in from the dunes, the Rovers ride out and handle it. Out in the Badlands, it's every soul for themselves. But here behind the wall... folks figured out that looking after each other was the only way not to drown in the grit."

Valis smiled warmly, resting his chin on his hands. "A commonwealth of mutual trust. How remarkably fragile... and how profoundly noble."

Tessa took a long drink of her chicory, wiping her mouth with the back of her glove. She looked over at the elegant, silk-clad Ancestral beside her. "Alright, bright-vest," she said. "I've laid out the whole messy circus. Now tell me about your lot. You've got six worlds of pristine spires in X'ara. You've got automated dynamos that never break down, cities where nobody yells, and fleets of silent ships with hard-light lances that could skewer a Flotilla cruiser before the captain finished reading his morning orders. Who runs the show on Irul?"

Valis set his cup down on the iron rail. He looked up at the sky, his expression shifting into something quiet, reverent, and ancient. "The Elder," Valis said softly.

"The Archon?" Tessa asked. "We hear rumors in the Flotilla corridors. An immortal ruler living deep inside the capital."

"He is not merely a ruler, Tessa," Valis said, his voice dropping to a melodious murmur. "He is our living father. Our revered god. When our civilization awoke from the long darkness millions of years ago, it was the Elder who gathered our ancestors. He taught us that the Sphere was not an accidental formation of cosmic gravity, but a sacred sanctuary constructed by the Precursors—the First Builders—and bequeathed to us, their chosen inheritors, so that we might dwell in everlasting peace."

Tessa raised an eyebrow. "And where does this Elder live? In a palace of solid diamond?"

Valis smiled—a small, enigmatic curve of his lips. "He lives everywhere. And nowhere. The Elder possesses the divine gift of wandering. He does not sit upon a golden throne surrounded by guards. He walks among us. He may take the form of an elderly gardener pruning the radiotrophic taiga on the northern slopes. He may be a weary traveler seeking shelter at a waystation in the glass plains of Irul'oa. He may be the quiet scholar reading an ancient scroll in the corner of the Great Scriptorium."

Tessa stared at him. "You're telling me your god wanders the streets in disguise? Like an Old Earth myth?"

"Precisely like your myths of Zeus or Odin," Valis nodded. "It is the foundational ethic of our entire culture. In Ancestral society, you never raise your voice to a stranger. You never turn away a traveler who asks for bread. You never strike a servant or mock an artisan. Because that humble individual, sweeping the dust from the marble portico, could be the Elder himself, testing the purity of your virtue."

Tessa let out a low whistle. "Damn. That's a hell of a way to keep people polite."

"It does ensure profound civility," Valis agreed. "And while the Elder is away—dwelling unrecognized amongst the populace, tending gardens or wandering the mountain trails—our world is administered by the **Triumvirate of the Firstborn**."

"And what do they do?"

"Nothing," Valis said simply.

Tessa blinked. "Nothing?"

"Their sacred charge," Valis explained, "is the preservation of the Sacred Vigil. Their duty is not to legislate, nor to reform, nor to conquer. Their duty is to ensure that tomorrow is mathematically, architecturally, and spiritually identical to yesterday. They ensure the dynamos continue to hum. They ensure the spires remain upright. They ensure that no new laws are written, no old traditions are broken, and that our people do not fall into the fatal sin of mortal ambition."

He looked out over the sprawling iron roofs and smelting towers of Dustwall, watching a heavy tracked crawler rumble through the streets below, its warning sirens wailing as it hauled a sixty-ton ingot of glowing iron toward the railhead. "It is a paradise, Tessa," Valis said softly. "It is peaceful. It is eternal. It is flawless. And it is completely, utterly suffocating."

Tessa turned her head, surprised by the sudden edge in his voice. "Suffocating?"

"Do you know why I wear this ridiculous vest?" Valis asked, touching the bright lemon pattern with a self-deprecating smile. "Do you know why I boarded a Flotilla transport and crossed ninety million kilometers of void just to inhale iron dust on a mining rock? I visited **Avon 2**," Valis murmured. "Across the binary gap from Avon 1, where the Pure Blade hawks sharpen their hard-light spears and preach hatred of Newcomer vulgarity. I stood in the Newcomer festival plaza during the solstice. I saw your people dancing. Humans, nagas, craggens, sylvans, elves, and drakelings, all linked arm-in-arm, drinking cheap fermented cider, laughing until their sides ached, shouting over the rules of a ballgame, and singing songs about ancient Earth mountains they have never seen."

He picked up his digital slate, running his thumb over the sleek glass casing. "On Irul'lia, nothing ever begins, and nothing ever ends. We have achieved perfection, and in doing so, we have frozen our history in amber. But here... on Landfall, on Nimbus, on Pelagia, even here behind the Dust Wall on Suncatcher... your people are imperfect. You argue. You bleed. You build cities that fall down, and then you rebuild them with better bricks. You invent games where grown men celebrate over a stitched leather ball. You have so little time, and so much dust, and yet you live with such frantic, desperate, magnificent joy. That is why I am a tourist, Tessa. On Irul'lia, I am an immortal statue waiting for eternity to notice me. Here, I am merely a traveler with dirty shoes. And it is the most extraordinary thing I have ever experienced."

A deep, mournful horn echoed across the high wall parapet. Across the afternoon sky, the colossal purple curve of **Nimbus** was sliding cleanly across the face of the sun. The blazing heat-shimmer over the desert basin wavered, collapsed, and vanished into a bruised twilight of deep amber and violet. The Pause had arrived.

Along the perimeter of Dustwall, the automated gas streetlamps lit with a staggered series of muffled pops, flickering in the icy breeze rushing across the cooling stone. Tessa pulled her heavy canvas jacket tighter around her chest, feeling the sharp drop in temperature against her cheeks. She smiled, picked up her thermos, and stood up. "Well, Valis, that's the eclipse. The rock will freeze to minus ten, and if we don't get inside, our chicory will turn into an icicle."

Valis stood beside her, pointing his optical sensor at Tessa—standing in her scuffed work suit, wrench in her belt, the vast purple shadow of Nimbus towering over her shoulder—and tapped the screen. The display flashed softly. "A splendid composition," Valis said happily. "Shall we proceed to the commissary? I understand they serve a dish called a 'pastrami sandwich' that is eaten entirely by hand, with no regard for finger cleanliness whatsoever."

Tessa was about to reply when two shadows detached themselves from a nearby recessed service alcove.

Her immediate instinct was mild, professional irritation. Flotilla inspectors had a tedious habit of showing up at planetary gates to check cargo manifests and demand maintenance logs right when a shift was ending. But as the two men stepped into the dim, amber glow of the gas lamp, a quiet note of wariness edged into her mind. They wore the charcoal-grey overcoats of fleet officers, their high collars fastened with polished silver clasps. But regular line officers did not look like this. Line officers who spent nine months a year in the void had frayed cuffs, coffee stains on their flight manuals, and that perpetually rumpled, exhausted look that came from sleeping in pressurized bunks next to a thrumming reactor core.

These two men had coats without a single fold or wrinkle. Their black boots were polished to a mirror shine that had clearly never touched Suncatcher's red dirt until about ten minutes ago. And on their lapels, the silver double-chevrons of the Transit Wing were completely, unnervingly blank. No division rockers. No squadron numerals. No ship crests. Every line officer Tessa had ever served with during her One-Year Tour would rather have their ears boxed by a boatswain than walk around without their ship's colors.

The lead officer stopped a polite two paces away, clasping his gloved hands loosely behind his back. He had clean, angular features, short iron-grey hair, and the calm, practiced smile of an accountant reviewing an overdue bill. "Operative Thorne," the man said. His voice was smooth, cultured, and devoid of any recognizable accent. "A pleasant evening on the rim. We trust your excursion has been informative?"

Hearing her name spoken by a stranger on a deserted gantry made her skin prickle. Her right thumb casually hooked into her work belt beside the heavy steel handle of her hydraulic spanner. "Pleasant enough," Tessa said, keeping her tone flat, careful, and unhurried. "Though usually when Transit inspectors come down to the surface, it's because a fuel lighter took out a communication relay. You're a long way from orbit, Commander."

"Special assignment," the officer replied, reaching smoothly into his coat to produce a slim, brushed-alloy data slate. "The Admiralty Board has been monitoring your charter with great interest. Given the delicate geopolitical posture across the Avon frontier, Central Command has determined that an Ancestral scholar touring an unsecured civilian mining colony presents an unacceptable risk."

He offered the slate. Across the glass display, official Flotilla cryptographic seals pulsed in steady green hashes—an emergency custody requisition stamped by Fleet Intelligence. "We have an enclosed diplomatic transport waiting on the outer freight spur," the second officer added quietly, stepping slightly to the flank to narrow Tessa's path to the airlock. "Climate-controlled, full medical suite, direct burn to Redmane Station. We'll relieve you of Scholar Valis from here, Operative. Your cell will receive full contracted disbursement, plus a twenty-percent administrative hazard bonus credited to your registry tonight."

It was all so agonizingly reasonable. Yet something was off. "The outer freight spur?" Tessa asked, her brow furrowing. "That's an unmonitored pad for bulk ore barges. The fleet landing hub is over by the main concourse."

The lead officer's smile didn't waver. "Discretion is paramount, Operative. Public berths attract unwanted observation."

She looked closer at the display in his hands. "And this authorization hash. Admiral Kaelen's office. Kaelen's division was folded into Logistics right after the Frontier War."

"A legacy administrative routing," the officer answered without hesitation. "Standard protocol for high-classification handovers. Please instruct your ward to collect his belongings."

Every response was instant, seamless, and completely flat. Not a flicker of irritation. Just frictionless, rehearsed perfection. And that was when the cold settled into her bones: *Shadow Wing.* The phantom branch that officially had no ships, no personnel, and no budget, but whose agents always showed up when a defector or an alien artifact needed to vanish. If these men took Valis, he was never reaching Redmane Station. They would dissect his understanding of Precursor physics in an unmarked asteroid lab.

Tessa looked at Valis, smiling by the rail at a flock of dust-crows in the twilight. *Damn it.* Walking him into a slaughterhouse to pay her hangar fees would rot her soul.

"I don't think so, Commander," Tessa said, keeping her tone casual despite the cold sweat prickling her collar. "Why don't we ask Valis who he wants to keep escorting him? An Ancestral scholar traveling on a registered visa... dragging him to an unmonitored spur sounds diplomatically messy."

Valis beamed, clasping his hands: "Most astute! Operative Thorne has proven an exceptionally attentive guide. Furthermore, we have an urgent culinary appointment at the concourse commissary for a pastrami sandwich. I respectfully decline your shuttle, gentlemen."

"Operative Thorne," the lead officer murmured softly, all pretense stripped away. "Do not allow sentimental delusions to shorten your lifespan." The second officer's hand slid beneath his coat toward a concealed sidearm.

The heavy airlock door swung open with a screech. Stepping out was Aldorman Grady himself in his oil-stained canvas duster, flanked by two Dustwall Rovers with cocked carbines and weighted bolas, followed by Marik the Craggen balancing a forty-pound pipe wrench, Ssaros the Naga with his ash bat, and half a dozen drillers smelling of chicory and tobacco.

"Something wrong out here, Tess?" Grady asked, his gravel voice cutting through the wind.

"This is a closed Flotilla matter, civilian," the lead operative snapped.

Grady spat chicory over the rail. "Don't know much about 'security matters,' son. Out in the void, you admiralty folks can play whatever games you like. But you're standing on Dustwall stone. If Scholar Valis wants to go inside and have a sandwich with Tess, he has a sandwich. If that hand under your coat comes out with iron in it, my Rovers are gonna wrap three pounds of lead bola around your knees and drop you forty feet into the slag sump. Now tuck your slate away."

Valis stepped between them, holding up his slate: "Officers! Before you depart, you simply must permit me to capture a photographic likeness! The brooding severity of your charcoal tailoring against this raw industrialism—hold that splendid expression of constitutional vigilance!" Valis tapped the display. The flash flared bright.

Slowly, the lead officer pocketed his slate. "Enjoy your dinner, Operative Thorne. Do keep your ward close. Accidents on the frontier are difficult to anticipate." The two phantoms turned and melted silently into the dark.

Tessa grabbed the railing to steady her shaking knees. Grady squeezed her shoulder: "Good spine, Tess. Your grandfather would've done the same. Come on inside."

"Come on, tourist," Tessa said, steering Valis through the hatch. "Let's get that pastrami sandwich before someone starts an interplanetary war over your scrapbook."

"Splendid!" Valis exclaimed, striding into the warm concourse in his radiant lemon vest. "And remember, Tessa—extra mustard. A proper cultural immersion requires one to risk genuine physical consequence."

ACT IV • THE WORLDS OF THE SPHERE

The journey continues across the celestial heavens. Turn the page to enter **Chapter 07: Worlds of the Sphere**—exploring the macro-engineering of the clockwork system, the planetary gazetteers of the Fume and X'ara clusters, the five-century timeline, and the sovereign faction dossiers of the civilized void.